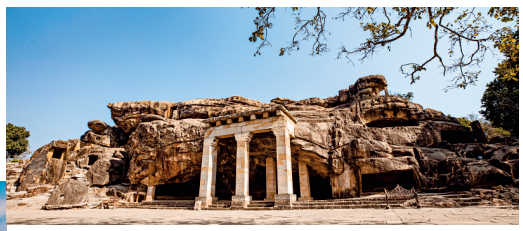

rock-cut caves were built somewhere around the 2nd century BC by King Kharavela. Set in the Kumari mountain range, the caves were built for Jain monks as a place to stay and meditate. Out of the 117 original caves only 33 survive today: 18 caves are located in the Udayagiri hill and 15 in the Khandagiri hill. The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) is in charge of the Udayagiri caves and it's a ticketed monument. Many of the caves are double storeyed. It is believed that the upper chambers were used for deep meditation. The most extraordinary achievement of these beautifully carved caves is that each cave and sculpture was painstakingly carved by hand using the most basic tools.

## RAGHURAJPUR HERITAGE CRAFTS VILLAGE

Raghurajpur is a heritage craft village 10 kilometres from Puri where each home is a veritable museum showcasing the work of the local artists. Pattachitra, one of Odisha's oldest art forms, is widely practised by the chitrakars in this village. Pattachitra focuses on depictions of Lord Jagannath. The term "patta chitra" comes from the Sanskrit for "canvas" and "cloth". The art form consists essentially of colourful paintings of mythological scenes on cloth. These days, you can find pattachitra artworks on tussar silks, palm leaves, coconuts, and betel nuts; they're also often turned into wall hangings and showpieces that visitors can take home as mementos.

## HANDLOOMS

The handlooms of Odisha make for heirloom-worthy wardrobe pieces. The most famous of the state's handloom techniques is ikat—a resist dyeing process in which bundles of yarn are tightly bound together and dipped into coloured dyes before being woven into cloth. Ikat features three distinctive weaving techniques—warp, weft, and double ikat—with typical designs comprising rows of birds, animals, and fish as well as motifs of temple spires. Sambalpuri ikat is considered some of the finest and is mostly produced by the Bhuliya community, who have been practicing the craft for centuries.

## RATH YATRA

The Rath Yatra, which usually takes place between June and July annually, is the Jagannath Temple's most important festival, and sees thousands of devotees vie with each other for an opportunity to pull the chariot. The festival marks Lord Jagannath's annual visit to Gundicha Temple via Mausi Maa Temple near Saradha Bali, Puri. The presiding deities of the Jagannath Temple–Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra and Goddess Subhadra–are removed from the temple in a ceremonial procession to their chariots. The huge, colourfully decorated chariots are then drawn by multitude of devotees on the bada danda, the grand avenue to the Gundicha Temple.

On their way back from the Gundicha Temple, the deities stop for a while near the Mausi Maa Temple (Aunt's abode) and have an offering of the Poda Pitha, a special type of pancake which is believed to be the Lord's favourite. After seven days, the deities return home.